

Interview summary: participant P3

One 17-minute interview: how this person handles the wait before a concert, and what they made of the crew pact and the pre-show missions.

The short version

The participant already has a system for meeting friends at a gig, and it is a social system rather than a technical one. They agree the plan in a group chat beforehand, they meet outside before going in, they pick a landmark, and they tell each other what colour clothes they are wearing. When that fails they send each other short videos of their surroundings. None of this needs an app, and they said as much without being prompted.

Given the choice between the two directions they picked the crew pact, and the reason they gave is more use to us than the choice itself. They chose it because it is *useful*, and they rejected the missions because they would be *tiring*, since they want to save their energy for the show. The thing being weighed there is how much attention they have to spend, which is a different question from which features are on offer.

What is wrong with the crew pact

The participant found the biggest problem with the design without being prompted, which is that the plan is agreed before anybody has seen the room.

Sometimes when because in some concert maybe we haven't went there before. So we don't know what the position about or what it looks like inside. So it is not really good to have some agreement or some decision which location we will make before we go inside.

Participant, 10:08 – 11:03

Their conclusion for a venue they do not know was direct: "I would think it is not work. I need to talk with my friends online." That goes straight at the offline stance, because the argument behind the design is that the agreement survives losing signal, while the participant's answer is that an agreement made without knowing the room is not worth surviving. A meet point chosen from a map is a guess, and if the guess lands somewhere crowded then the group is worse off than it would be if it could renegotiate.

The coarse state, which sends "at the bar" instead of a location, got a more balanced answer. It works when the group has already agreed on something identifiable such as the colour of their clothes, and it stops working when the crowd is too dense, at which point they send video of what they can see instead. So the substitution at the centre of the design covers about half of what these people already do, and the half it leaves out carries more information than a location pin does.

The missions, and why they would go unused

The first reaction was warm, "it sounds really fun and interesting", and the participant volunteered that they might make new friends. Every qualification that came after it pulled the other way, and those qualifications are where the useful material is.

Whether they take part depends on what the task is and on whether they have time, and most of all it depends on whether they are on their own. Asked about doing a mission with a stranger, they described feeling awkward and called themselves a shy person. The answer got firmer once the question moved to coming to the concert alone, because in that case they would not take part at all. Having a friend there changes it completely, since friends push each other into doing things.

If I have a friend maybe we will encourage each other to take part in this activity but if I come there alone I don't want to take part in that.

Participant, 14:40 – 15:04

That turns the premise of the direction upside down, because pre-show missions look like a way of warming up a room full of strangers, and for this person they only work with the people they already arrived with, who are the same group the crew pact was designed for. The objection about energy sits underneath both directions, since a concert already costs them a great deal of standing and singing, and anything that spends attention before the show is spending it on something other than the show.

Something neither direction covers

The most vivid moment in the interview had nothing to do with either prototype. Asked about a time they wanted to talk to somebody and did not, the participant described sitting beside a stranger who turned out to be a fan of the same artist, intending to speak to her, and then losing her in the dark and in the crush at the end.

That is the loneliness the project set out to work on, described without being asked, and neither direction does anything about it. The crew pact is built for people who arrived together and the missions are built for people who have the energy to join in, so a person sitting in the dark beside somebody they would like to speak to is left out of both.

The other story they told without being asked is worth keeping for a different reason. They described helping a wheelchair user reach a seat through a crowd that could not see him. Whatever the team builds will be used in that same crowd, and this participant is somebody who notices it.

How much one interview is worth

This is one person, and the answers are consistent with somebody who goes to concerts with an established group and does not want to be stretched socially while they are there. Somebody who goes alone by choice, or who goes in order to meet people, would probably answer the missions question the other way round. The preference for the crew pact is one vote from a person who explained clearly why

the missions would cost them something, and it should not be read as evidence that the crew pact is the better design.

There are three things the interviewer did not ask and should ask next time.

The participant said that an agreement made before seeing the venue is not much good, and nobody asked the obvious follow-up, which is what would have to be true for it to work. Arriving early enough to look around first might do it, or a venue they already know, or a meet point described by something findable without a map. The objection was taken at face value instead of being opened up.

Nobody asked what happens when the plan fails. The case for the crew pact rests on it holding when the signal goes, and there was no question about a night where somebody was late or lost or went home early, which is when an agreement actually gets tested.

The missions were only ever discussed as something the participant would do themselves, and nobody asked how it would feel to be the person *not* taking part while a leaderboard on a shared screen shows everybody who is.

A NOTE ON HOW THE QUESTIONS WERE PUT

Several questions in this interview were long, and a few of them contained the answer. The strongest material came back in response to the shortest questions, including the objection about venues they do not know, the difference between coming alone and coming with a friend, and the argument about energy. That is worth carrying into the next interview.